**MEDIA ADVISORY FOR RELEASE-** September 18, 2024 @ 8AM
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# Santa Clara County Education Community Calls for Contract Action Following Superintendent Misappropriation and Retaliation Scandal

*SEIU 521 SCCOE chapter will hold a rally to demand innovative reforms through a union contract that establishes safety protections, management accountability, and equity for all SCCOE workers.*

**Who:** SEIU 521 Members at Santa Clara County Office of Education (SCCOE)
**What:** Protest Rally
**When:** September 18, 2024, at 4:00 p.m.
**Where:** Santa Clara County Office of Education, 1290 Ridder Park Drive

SEIU 521 members of the Santa Clara County Office of Education will rally on September 18 @ 4:00 PM to demand a fair contract that includes safety, equity accountability of management for SCCOE workers. While SCCOE leadership claims they cannot afford reforms to promote recruitment and retention in hard to fill positions like Head start, SCCOE held $87+ million above county mandated reserves without creating work-from-home policies which cost nothing.

“As a parent of an SCCOE special needs child, I witnessed the damage caused by the Superintendent’s Office, to reduce special education services,” said **Santa Clara County resident Barbara Rodriguez.** “Insufficient staff means my child isn’t getting consistent support he needs at school. SCCOE needs to serve the interests of our special education students and invest directly into staff whoo serve our students.”

The rally coincides with Superintendent Mary Ann Dewan’s annual evaluation and goal setting, with staff and families calling for structural changes, equity and transparency to address the impact of discriminatory and rapidly increasing management to staff hiring ratios. SCCOE employees face threats of demotions, reassignments, relocations in retaliation for speaking up. Frequent injuries in special education classrooms and Cal-OSHA complaints continue to deteriorate morale.

"We can’t effectively serve students in a culture of mismanagement, intimidation, and insufficient staff," said **Sarah Gianocaro, SCCOE SEIU 521 Chapter President.** “Our contract must prioritize equitable compensation and policies, and with over $87 million in unspent funds, we SCCOE can afford to invest in reforms. The superintendent can and will direct her team to meet our demands at the bargaining table."

**What SEIU 521 SCCOE workers are demanding:**

- A fair contract, including the end to staggered and short-staffing in classrooms, boosting the substitute worker pool, equitable longevity and interpretation pay and a viable remote work policy, that protects workers' rights and secures the future of education in Santa Clara County.
- Transparency and accountability in the superintendent's evaluation and goal setting reflecting union and community priorities
- An end to retaliatory practices against workers
- Full transparency and accountability in the handling of Head Start
- Invest a portion of the surplus funds in students and staff

**Rally Visuals**

Union members, parents, and community allies will gather with signs and banners calling for justice for workers and students. Parents of children in special education programs will share their stories of how the structural failings have affected their families. "Join us to protect our children's education and demand justice for SCCOE workers!"

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*Service Employees International Union, Local 521 represents 53,000 public- and nonprofit, private-sector workers in California's Bay Area, the Central Coast, and in the Central Valley. Under a Community First vision, we are committed to making sure the needs of our community, and the vital services we provide our community, come first. We believe our communities thrive when residents, leaders and workers recognize that we are all in this together when it comes to our safety, health, and well-being.*